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I

I am

In the Old Testament, when God calls Moses, Moses asks God for his name. God then says: “I am who I am.” Or, God could also mean “I am who I will be.” In Hebrew, the language of the Old Testament, this answer from God sounds like Yahweh. This word Yahweh became the name that the Israelites used for God. Whenever the Israelites hear the words “I am,” they are reminded of this name for God. In the New Testament, Jesus says to the people that “even before Abraham was born, I am.” Jewish people who heard this may have thought about the name Yahweh. They may have realized that Jesus was telling the people that he himself was God. There are other places too where Jesus talks about himself by saying “I am...” something. For instance, Jesus says, “I am the way,” or “I am the bread of life.” It is possible that every time that Jesus said “I am,” he was hinting to the people that he is God.

I am

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idol

An **idol** is an object that people make in order to worship a god. The object reminds the people about some characteristics of this god. In the Bible these are sometimes called “images.” People make an object—an image—of a god and worship that object as if it is that god. People could make such an object out of stone, wood, or metal. Such an object could look like a person, or like an animal, or just have any different shape. They could be very large, or they could be small and able to easily carry. The word idol can also refer to things or ideas that people worship more than God himself.

God forbade the Israelites in his commandments to ever make such an idol, or image, or to worship anything else besides God himself.

idol

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image of God

An image is a picture of something. A photo, a painting, or a statue of a person is the image of a person.

The image tells us something about what the person looks like, or what his character is like.

When God created mankind, God said “let us make mankind in our image. Mankind will look like us. And mankind will rule over all the animals and plants on the earth.”

So, all people are created in the image of God. This does not mean that people physically look like God, because God is spirit and does not have a body as we have. But it means that people are representing God on earth. God gave people responsibility to take care of the earth. People are supposed to take care of animals, plants, and the whole of nature, in the name of, or on behalf of, God.

In the New Testament, we learn that Jesus is the ultimate image of God. We cannot see God, but we can see Jesus, and when we look at Jesus we know what God is like. As followers of Jesus we must become images of Jesus—we must look more and more like Jesus.

image of God

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immorality

When people do sexual sin of any kind, we say that they are **immoral**. When a married man or a married woman has sexual relations outside of their marriage, we say that they are committing adultery. However, when the Bible says that someone does immoral things, they can be doing any kind of sexual sin. Usually when someone is immoral, they are doing some kind of sexual sin when they are not married. Sometimes, biblical authors use the description “immoral” to talk about people who worship idols instead of worshipping God. Just like men or women are unfaithful to each other when they sin with someone sexually, someone who worships a false god or idol instead of the true God is unfaithful to God. We can call those people immoral as well.

immorality

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inn

An **inn** is a general term for a place where travelers can stay. This could be a place where people had to pay some money so that they could stay there, but often it meant a room in someone’s house that was

reserved for guests. When relatives or friends came to visit, they could stay in this room.

inn

Audio Content

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Isaiah

Isaiah was a prophet who lived about 700 years before Jesus. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. Many of Isaiah's messages have been written down and we can hear them in the book named Isaiah.

At the time that Isaiah lived, the nation of Israel had been divided in two parts. The northern part was called Israel, and the southern part was called Judah. Isaiah gave his messages especially to the people of Judah. Many people of Judah were worshipping false gods, and did not obey the good rules that God had given them. Isaiah warned the people again and again that they should repent and start obeying God, because God was going to punish them. But Isaiah also gave people messages of hope. He told them that God was going to send someone who would make things right again. God fulfilled these promises of making things right again in Jesus.

Isaiah

Audio Content

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Israel

Israel is the name of the territory where the Israelites lived. The name comes from Abraham's grandson, Israel. Abraham was the first ancestor of the Israelites. Abraham's grandson was named Jacob, but God later gave Jacob the name Israel. Since that time, Jacob's descendants are called Israelites.

At some point, the Israelites fought among themselves, and because of this the nation of Israel split in two parts. The southern part became known as Judah, while the northern part was still called Israel.

Because of all this, sometimes the word Israel refers to one man, namely Abraham's grandson Jacob who was later called Israel.

Sometimes the word Israel refers to all the descendants of Jacob together. It then means the same as Israelites, or as people of Israel.

Sometimes the word Israel refers to the land, or the territory, where the Israelites lived.

And sometimes the word Israel refers only to the northern part of that territory.

Today, Israel is the name of the country formed as a homeland for the Jewish people after 1948. This is not exactly the same area of land where the biblical Israelites lived.

Israel

Audio Content

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Israelite

Israelites are descendants of Jacob. Abraham, Jacob's grandfather, was a man who lived about 2000 years before the birth of Jesus. When Abraham was 75 years old, God spoke to him. God told him to leave behind his homeland, and to go to a place that God would show him. God said that he would bless Abraham, that he would make a great nation out of him, and that God would bless all the nations of the world through Abraham. Abraham obeyed God and God led him to the region that was at that time called Canaan. God promised Abraham that God would give this land to Abraham's descendants. Abraham and his wife did not have any children, but when Abraham and his wife were already very old, God gave them a son, Isaac. This was the beginning of God fulfilling his promise to Abraham.

Abraham's son Isaac had a son named Jacob. God later gave Jacob the name Israel. From that time onwards, all Jacob's descendants are called Israelites. Jacob had 12 sons, and therefore the Israelites were divided into 12 tribes: Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun, Dan, Naphtali, Gad, Asher, Joseph, and Benjamin. The tribe of Joseph was divided in two "half tribes": Ephraim and Manasseh.

Because God had made a promise to Abraham, and then to Isaac and Jacob, the Israelites were God's special people. God made a covenant with them, which is a promise with a special agreement. The agreement was that the Israelites would obey all God's commandments, and God would bless them and make them a blessing for all the people on the earth.

The land where the Israelites lived was called Israel. This land was divided among the different tribes of Israel. First, people called "judges" ruled the Israelites. When the people asked God to give them a king, God appointed a king to rule over them. At first this went well, and under the rule of king David and his son Solomon the kingdom of Israel became large and prosperous. But when king Solomon died, there was

conflict. Ten of the 12 tribes did not want to have the son of king Solomon as their king. They separated from the other two tribes and chose their own king.

From that time onwards, Israel was divided into parts. The northern part, with 10 tribes, was still called Israel. The southern part, with two tribes, was called Judah. It was called Judah because the tribe of Judah was the largest of the two tribes that together formed this southern kingdom.

Each part had their own king. The nation of Assyria defeated the northern part, Israel, about 700 years before the birth of Jesus. This happened because the people were continuously disobeying God and breaking the covenant. The king of the Assyrians sent most of the people from Israel away to foreign countries. This was the end of the northern kingdom. We never hear anything more about what happened to these people.

The kingdom of Judah lasted a little bit longer, but after some years God also punished them for their disobedience. Another foreign nation, the Babylonians, came and destroyed the city of Jerusalem, and the Babylonians took many of the people from Judah to Babylon as prisoners. The people from Judah were now called Jews, which means “people from Judah.” Later, God allowed the Jews to go back to Judah, where they rebuilt the city of Jerusalem and the temple. But Judah would never become an independent kingdom again. In the time of the New Testament, another nation named Rome was ruling over the area that had been Israel. What had been the southern kingdom of Judah, was now called the Roman province of Judea. What had been the northern kingdom of Israel, was now roughly the Roman provinces of Samaria and Galilee. The word Jew had now begun to refer to all remaining descendants of Jacob, no matter where they lived.

Israelite

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